

throughout your home. A furnace will last up to twenty-five years and starts around \$3,000. Whether or not air-conditioning is common depends on your area, but it is pricey to repair and even pricier to install if the home doesn't already have the ductwork in place.

- **Water heater.** A water heater will typically last about ten years and can cost \$1,000 or more to replace, so you should be aware if it's near the end of its life span. This probably isn't a deal breaker, but you could try to get a seller concession to cover this cost in advance.

Frankly, it's impossible for us to review every potential inspection report scenario in this book. Talk to your agent about anything in your inspection report that seems confusing or scary. Talk to any friends or family members who are knowledgeable about construction or may have performed similar home repairs in the past. Confer with a specialist or handyman—but do it all very quickly with your inspection objection deadline in mind.

HIRING TARGETED SPECIALISTS

Throughout your home inspection report, you will see comments that say something like, “Recommend contacting a licensed professional for further evaluation.” Your inspector is able to call out that there *is* a problem, but because they're not a structural engineer, plumber, or electrician, they can't give you any professional advice within the report on how to *fix* the problem.

This is where attending the inspection comes in handy. You want to ask the inspector in person if they feel this is a serious issue. They are probably going to say, “I recommend contacting a licensed professional for further evaluation. But, in my opinion...” Sometimes they'll hint that it's not a big problem, but sometimes they'll emphasize that you should *really* get it checked out by a specialist.

While it can be difficult to spend *another* \$600 on *another* inspection with *another* licensed professional, it is much worse to buy a home and discover an expensive problem. If you're willing to take on a home with any of the bigger problems listed above, you should have a specialist come in and evaluate the scope of the problem and estimate the cost of fixing it.